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Which of the following most logically completes the argument given?

Asthma, a chronic breathing disorder, is significantly more common today among adult competitive swimmers than it is among competitive athletes who specialize in other sports. Although chlorine is now known to be a lung irritant and swimming pool water is generally chlorinated, it would be rash to assume that frequent exposure to chlorine is the explanation of the high incidence of asthma among these swimmers, since _____.

A. young people who have asthma are no more likely to become competitive athletes than are young people who do not have asthma

B. competitive athletes who specialize in sports other than swimming are rarely exposed to chlorine

C. competitive athletes as a group have a significantly lower incidence of asthma than do people who do not participate in competitive athletics

D. until a few years ago, physicians routinely recommended competitive swimming to children with asthma, in the belief that this form of exercise could alleviate asthma symptoms

E. many people have asthma without knowing they have it and thus are not diagnosed with the condition until they begin engaging in very strenuous activities, such as competitive athletics

Argument Construction

Situation Asthma is more common among competitive swimmers than among other competitive athletes. Chlorine is a lung irritant generally present in swimming pool water.

Reasoning *What would cast doubt on the hypothesis that exposure to chlorine in swimming pools accounts for the high incidence of asthma among adult competitive swimmers?* Evidence of any other factor that would provide an alternative explanation of why asthma is more common among adult competitive swimmers than among other competitive athletes would make it rash to assume that frequent exposure to chlorine explains the high incidence of asthma among these swimmers, so a statement providing such evidence would logically fill in the blank at the end of the passage to complete the argument.

A. This might help explain why competitive athletes in general are not especially likely to have asthma, but it does not explain why adult competitive swimmers are more likely to have asthma than other competitive athletes are.

B. This provides additional evidence that exposure to chlorine explains why adult competitive swimmers are more likely to have asthma than other competitive athletes are, so it does not cast doubt on that hypothesis.

C. A lower incidence of asthma among competitive athletes than among nonathletes does not help explain the higher incidence of asthma among adult competitive swimmers than among other competitive athletes.

D. **Correct.** Routinely encouraging children with asthma to take up competitive swimming would likely have made the proportion of adult competitive swimmers with asthma exceed the proportion of other competitive athletes with asthma, even if chlorine in swimming pool water never causes asthma in swimmers.

E. This might help explain why people with asthma are just as likely as other people to become competitive athletes, but it does not help explain why adult competitive swimmers are more likely to have asthma than other competitive athletes are.

The correct answer is D.

•

In the country of Marut, the Foreign Trade Agency's records were reviewed in 1994 in light of information then newly available about neighboring Goro. The review revealed that in every year since 1963, the agency's projection of what Goro's gross national product (GNP) would be five years later was a serious underestimate. The review also revealed that in every year since 1963, the agency estimated Goro's GNP for the previous year—a Goro state secret—very accurately.

Of the following claims, which is most strongly supported by the statements given?

A. Goro's GNP fluctuated greatly between 1963 and 1994.

B. Prior to 1995, Goro had not released data intended to mislead the agency in making its five-year projections.

C. The amount by which the agency underestimated the GNP it projected for Goro tended to increase over time

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C. The amount by which the agency underestimated the GNP it projected for Goro tended to increase over time.

D. Even before the new information came to light, the agency had reason to think that at least some of the five-year projections it had made were inaccurate.

E. The agency's five-year projections of Goro's GNP had no impact on economic planning in Marut.

Argument Construction

Situation A review in 1994 revealed that every year since 1963, Marut's Foreign Trade Agency had seriously underestimated what Goro's GNP would be five years later but accurately estimated what Goro's GNP had been the previous year.

Reasoning *What conclusion do the stated facts most strongly support?* Goro's GNP in each year at least from 1969 through 1993 had been seriously underestimated by the agency five years in advance, yet was then accurately estimated by the agency one year after the fact. It follows that for each of these years, the agency's earlier projection of Goro's GNP must have been much lower than its later estimate.

A. This is not supported by the information given. The fact that the agency consistently underestimated each year's GNP in its five-year projections and then correctly estimated it after the fact does not indicate that Goro's GNP fluctuated greatly.

B. This is not supported by the information given. The reason the agency's five-year projections were inaccurate might well have been that Goro deliberately released data intended to mislead the agency in making those projections.

C. This is not supported by the information given. The fact that the underestimates remained large throughout the years in question does not indicate that the underestimates increased over time.

D. **Correct.** As explained above, for many years there were serious discrepancies between the agency's five-year projections of Goro's GNP and its retrospective estimates of each previous year's trade. In any year at least from 1970 through 1993, these discrepancies, if noticed, would have given the agency reason to doubt some of the five-year projections.

E. This is not supported by the information given. Even though at least some of the five-year projections were eventually known to be serious underestimates, they could still have affected Marut's economic planning. The economic planners might have retained an unreasonable faith in the accuracy of the most recent projections.

The correct answer is D.

•

Vargonia has just introduced a legal requirement that student-teacher ratios in government-funded schools not exceed a certain limit. All Vargonian children are entitled to education, free of charge, in these schools. When a recession occurs and average incomes fall, the number of children enrolled in government-funded schools tends to increase. Therefore, though most employment opportunities contract in economic recessions, getting a teaching job in Vargonia's government-funded schools will not be made more difficult by a recession.

Which of the following would be most important to determine in order to evaluate the argument?

A. Whether in Vargonia there are any schools not funded by the government that offer children an education free of charge

B. Whether the number of qualified applicants for teaching positions in government-funded schools increases significantly during economic recessions

C. What the current student-teacher ratio in Vargonia's government-funded schools is

D. What proportion of Vargonia's workers currently hold jobs as teachers in government-funded schools

E. Whether in the past a number of government-funded schools in Vargonia have had student-teacher ratios well in excess of the new limit

Argument Evaluation

Situation During a recession, the number of children in government-funded schools in Vargonia tends to increase. Vargonian children are entitled to a free education in these schools. A new law requires student-teacher ratios in these schools to remain below a certain limit.

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student-teacher ratios in these schools to remain below a certain limit.

Reasoning *Which of the five questions would provide us with the best information for evaluating the argument?* The argument's conclusion is that recessions do not make teaching jobs in Vargonia's government-funded schools harder to get. During recessions, the reasoning goes, more students will enroll in Vargonia's government-funded schools than in nonrecession times. Implicit in the argument is the thought that, because the new law sets an upper limit on the average number of students per teacher, schools that get an influx of new students would have to hire more teachers. During a recession, however, there might be much more competition in the labor market for teachers because many more qualified people are applying for teaching jobs.

A. This information is not significant in the context of the argument, which does not need to assume that only government-funded schools provide free education.

B. **Correct.** Getting an answer to this question would provide us with specific information useful in evaluating the argument. A "yes" answer to this question would suggest that competition for teaching jobs in Vargonian government-funded schools would be keener during recessions. A "no" answer would suggest that the level of competition would decrease during recessions.

C. Discovering the current student-teacher ratio in Vargonia's schools would be of no value, by itself, in evaluating the argument. We do not know what the new upper limit on the student-teacher ratio is, and we do not know whether Vargonia is currently in a recession.

D. Finding out whether the proportion this refers to is 1 percent, for example, or 4 percent, would tell us nothing about whether getting teaching jobs at government-funded schools in Vargonia becomes more difficult during a recession. Among other things, we do not know whether Vargonia is currently in a recession, and we do not know what proportion of Vargonia's workers would be qualified candidates for teaching jobs.

E. This is of no relevance in evaluating the argument because, presumably, the new limit on student-teacher ratios will be complied with. Thus, even if student-teacher ratios in the past would have exceeded the new limit, the argument concerns whether, *in the future*, getting a teaching job in Vargonia's government-funded schools will be made more difficult by a recession.

The correct answer is B.

•

In Colorado subalpine meadows, nonnative dandelions co-occur with a native flower, the larkspur. Bumblebees visit both species, creating the potential for interactions between the two species with respect to pollination. In a recent study, researchers selected 16 plots containing both species; all dandelions were removed from eight plots; the remaining eight control plots were left undisturbed. The control plots yielded significantly more larkspur seeds than the dandelion-free plots, leading the researchers to conclude that the presence of dandelions facilitates pollination (and hence seed production) in the native species by attracting more pollinators to the mixed plots.

Which of the following, if true, most seriously undermines the researchers' reasoning?

A. Bumblebees preferentially visit dandelions over larkspurs in mixed plots.

B. In mixed plots, pollinators can transfer pollen from one species to another to augment seed production.

C. If left unchecked, nonnative species like dandelions quickly crowd out native species.

D. Seed germination is a more reliable measure of a species' fitness than seed production.

E. Soil disturbances can result in fewer blooms, and hence lower seed production.

Argument Evaluation

Situation Bumblebees visit both larkspur and dandelions in certain meadows. A study found that more larkspur seeds were produced in meadow plots in which both larkspur and dandelions grew than in similar plots from which all dandelions had been removed. The researchers inferred that dandelions facilitate larkspur pollination.

Reasoning *What evidence would cast the most doubt on the inference from the study's findings to the conclusion that dandelions facilitate larkspur pollination by attracting more pollinators?* The argument assumes that the only relevant difference between the two types of plots was whether dandelions were present. Evidence that the plots differed in some other way that could provide a plausible alternative

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Evidence that the plots differed in some other way that could provide a plausible alternative explanation of why more larkspur seeds were produced in the plots with dandelions would weaken the argument.

A. This would suggest that the larkspur pollination should have been lower in the plots with dandelions, so it does not provide a plausible alternative explanation for the study's findings.

B. This is fully compatible with the claim that the dandelions attracted more pollinators to the mixed plots, and it would also help to support the argument's conclusion that dandelions facilitated larkspur pollination in those plots.

C. Although this suggests that the mixed plots won't remain mixed for long, it does not provide a plausible alternative explanation for the study's finding that larkspur seed production was higher in the mixed plots.

D. The argument is not about how fit larkspurs are as a species but about why they produced different numbers of seeds in the different plots.

E. **Correct.** This provides a plausible alternative explanation for why larkspur seed production was lower in the plots from which dandelions had been removed, since digging them out would have disturbed the soil.

The correct answer is E.

•

Paleontologist: About 2.8 million years ago, many species that lived near the ocean floor suffered substantial population declines. These declines coincided with the onset of an ice age. The notion that cold killed those bottom-dwelling creatures outright is misguided, however; temperatures near the ocean floor would have changed very little. Nevertheless, **the cold probably did cause the population declines, though indirectly**. Many bottom-dwellers depended on plankton, small organisms that lived close to the surface and sank to the bottom when they died, for food. **Most probably, the plankton suffered a severe population decline as a result of sharply lower temperatures at the surface,** depriving many bottom-dwellers of food.

In the paleontologist's reasoning, the two portions in **boldface** play which of the following roles?

A. The first introduces the hypothesis proposed by the paleontologist; the second is a judgment offered in spelling out that hypothesis.

B. The first introduces the hypothesis proposed by the paleontologist; the second is a position the paleontologist opposes.

C. The first is an explanation challenged by the paleontologist; the second is an explanation proposed by the paleontologist.

D. The first is a judgment advanced in support of a conclusion reached by the paleontologist; the second is that conclusion.

E. The first is a generalization put forward by the paleontologist; the second presents certain exceptional cases in which that generalization does not hold.

Evaluation of a Plan

Situation At the beginning of an ice age roughly 2.8 million years ago, many species of deep-sea animals suffered sharp drops in population. Because temperatures at those depths would have been very modestly affected, the author rejects the conclusion that cold killed these animals directly. Rather, the author suggests cold had an indirect impact by killing off surface-dwelling plankton since the bottom-dwelling animals relied on dead plankton drifting downward for food. The author concludes that sharp declines in plankton populations near the ocean surface likely led to population declines among species far below.

Reasoning *Two key phrases are in **boldface**: What function does each phrase perform?* The first phrase states the cold probably had an indirect impact on populations of deep-sea animals. This constitutes a hypothesis proposed by the author to explain the correlation between the beginning of an ice age and sharp drops in population among bottom-dwelling animals. The second phrase states the cold probably killed a large proportion of plankton near the surface. This is a judgment spelling out the hypothesis that cold was indirectly responsible for deep-sea population declines by identifying a mechanism that would show how cold could have that effect.

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show how cold could have that effect.

A. **Correct.** The first phrase presents the author's hypothesis that cold indirectly caused population declines among deep-sea species; the second phrase, that the cold likely killed a large proportion of the plankton, is a judgment regarding probable effects of the cold that spells out the details of how that hypothesis would work.

B. While the first phrase is the author's hypothesis, the author endorses rather than opposes the position in the second phrase—that cold probably killed off a large proportion of the plankton.

C. The author challenges the explanation that cold was *directly* responsible for population declines among deep-sea species; the first phrase, that cold was *indirectly* responsible, is the explanation the author proposes, and the second phrase elaborates on that explanation.

D. The first phrase is a hypothesis, not a judgment; the second phrase develops that hypothesis rather than drawing a conclusion.

E. The first phrase presents a hypothesis, not a generalization, and the second phrase develops that hypothesis rather than saying anything about exceptional cases.

The correct answer is A.

•

With seventeen casinos, Moneyland operates the most casinos in a certain state. Although intent on expanding, it was outmaneuvered by Apex Casinos in negotiations to acquire the Eldorado chain. To complete its acquisition of Eldorado, Apex must sell five casinos to comply with a state law forbidding any owner to operate more than one casino per county. Since Apex will still be left operating twenty casinos in the state, it will then have the most casinos in the state.

Which of the following, if true, most seriously undermines the prediction?

A. Apex, Eldorado, and Moneyland are the only organizations licensed to operate casinos in the state.

B. The majority of Eldorado's casinos in the state will need extensive renovations if they are to continue to operate profitably.

C. Some of the state's counties do not permit casinos.

D. Moneyland already operates casinos in the majority of the state's counties.

E. Apex will use funds it obtains from the sale of the five casinos to help fund its acquisition of the Eldorado chain.

Argument Evaluation

Situation Moneyland operates seventeen casinos, the most in a certain state, and is intent on expanding. Another operator, Apex Casinos, is acquiring the Eldorado casino chain but must sell five casinos to comply with a state law forbidding any owner to operate more than one casino per county. After these transactions, Apex will operate twenty casinos in the state.

Reasoning *What observation would cast the most doubt on the prediction that Apex will have the most casinos in the state after the transactions?* Apex will operate twenty casinos, whereas Moneyland now operates just seventeen, and no one else operates even that many. It follows that Apex will operate more casinos after its transactions than Moneyland or any other one owner now operates. However, if Moneyland also acquires three or more casinos during the transactions, then Apex will not have the most casinos in the state afterward. Thus, any observation suggesting that Moneyland is about to acquire several casinos would undermine the prediction.

A. **Correct.** Since Apex is acquiring Eldorado, Moneyland and Apex will be the only remaining licensed casino operators in the state. Therefore, Moneyland is the only likely buyer for the five casinos Apex needs to sell. So, Moneyland is likely to acquire the five casinos during the sale and end up with twenty-two casinos—more than Apex.

B. This does not undermine the prediction. Even if the Eldorado casinos cannot operate profitably for long without extensive renovations, Apex will still have twenty casinos immediately after its transactions.

C. This supports rather than undermines the prediction. If fewer counties permit casinos, there will be fewer opportunities for Moneyland or any other operator to acquire more casinos to surpass the twenty Apex will own.

D. This supports rather than undermines the prediction. If Moneyland operates casinos in most of the state,

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D. This supports rather than undermines the prediction. If Moneyland's seventeen casinos are in most of the state's counties already, then there are fewer counties in which Moneyland could acquire additional casinos to surpass the twenty Apex will own.

E. This supports rather than undermines the prediction. Apex's use of the funds from selling the five casinos to acquire the Eldorado chain will not help anyone else to acquire more casinos to surpass the twenty Apex will own.

The correct answer is A.

•

It is widely assumed that people need to engage in intellectual activities such as solving crossword puzzles or mathematics problems in order to maintain mental sharpness as they age. In fact, however, simply talking to other people—that is, participating in social interaction, which engages many mental and perceptual skills—suffices. Evidence to this effect comes from a study showing that the more social contact people report, the better their mental skills.

Which of the following, if true, most seriously weakens the force of the evidence cited?

A. As people grow older, they are often advised to keep exercising their physical and mental capacities in order to maintain or improve them.

B. Many medical conditions and treatments that adversely affect a person's mental sharpness also tend to increase that person's social isolation.

C. Many people are proficient both in social interactions and in solving mathematical problems.

D. The study did not itself collect data but analyzed data bearing on the issue from prior studies.

E. The tasks evaluating mental sharpness for which data were compiled by the study were more akin to mathematics problems than to conversation.

Argument Evaluation

Situation	A study shows that the more social contact people report, the better their mental skills are, so engaging in social interaction is sufficient for maintaining mental sharpness.
Reasoning	*What would suggest that the study does not establish the truth of the conclusion?* The study shows a correlation between mental sharpness and social interaction but does not indicate why this correlation exists. Evidence that mental sharpness contributes to social interaction, or that some third factor affects both mental sharpness and social interaction, could provide an alternative explanation for the correlation and thus cast doubt on the explanation that social interaction contributes to mental sharpness.

A. People are often wrongly advised to do things that are not actually beneficial. And even if exercising mental capacities does help to maintain them, the passage says that social interaction provides such exercise.

B. **Correct.** This provides evidence that the correlation observed in the study results from mental sharpness facilitating social interaction, in which case the study results do not indicate that social interaction facilitates mental sharpness.

C. This would be expected, given the argument's conclusion that social interaction helps to maintain better mental skills overall.

D. A study that analyzes data from prior studies can provide evidence just as well as a study that collects its own data can.

E. The argument's conclusion would be compatible with this observation and would then suggest that social interaction contributes to the mental sharpness needed for tasks similar to math problems.

The correct answer is B.

•

In the United States, of the people who moved from one state to another when they retired, the percentage who retired to Florida has decreased by three percentage points over the past ten years. Since many local businesses in Florida cater to retirees, these declines are likely to have a noticeably negative economic effect on these businesses and

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therefore on the economy of Florida.

Which of the following, if true, most seriously weakens the argument given?

A. People who moved from one state to another when they retired moved a greater distance, on average, last year than such people did ten years ago.

B. People were more likely to retire to North Carolina from another state last year than people were ten years ago.

C. The number of people who moved from one state to another when they retired has increased significantly over the past ten years.

D. The number of people who left Florida when they retired to live in another state was greater last year than it was ten years ago.

E. Florida attracts more people who move from one state to another when they retire than does any other state.

Argument Evaluation

Situation Of those people who move to another state when they retire, the percentage moving to Florida has declined. This trend is apt to harm Florida's economy because many businesses there cater to retirees.

Reasoning *Which of the options most weakens the argument?* The argument draws its conclusion from data about the *proportion* of emigrating retirees moving to Florida. Yet what matters more directly to the conclusion (and to Florida's economy) is the *absolute number* of retirees immigrating to Florida. That number could have remained constant, or even risen, if the absolute number of emigrating retirees itself increased while the proportion going to Florida decreased.

A. This has no obvious bearing on the argument one way or another. It makes it more likely, perhaps, that a person in a distant state will retire to Florida but less likely that one in a neighboring state will do so.

B. This has no bearing on whether fewer people have been retiring to Florida over the last ten years.

C. **Correct.** This is the option that most seriously weakens the argument.

D. This makes it *more* likely that Florida's economy will be harmed because of decreasing numbers of retirees, but it has no real bearing on the argument which concludes specifically that *declines in the proportion of emigrating retirees moving to Florida* will have a negative effect on the state's economy.

E. This is irrelevant. At issue is how the numbers of retirees in Florida from one year compare to the next, not how those numbers compare with numbers of retirees in other states.

The correct answer is C.

•

The spacing of the four holes on a fragment of a bone flute excavated at a Neanderthal campsite is just what is required to play the third through sixth notes of the diatonic scale—the seven-note musical scale used in much of Western music since the Renaissance. Musicologists therefore hypothesize that the diatonic musical scale was developed and used thousands of years before it was adopted by Western musicians.

Which of the following, if true, most strongly supports the hypothesis?

A. Bone flutes were probably the only musical instrument made by Neanderthals.

B. No musical instrument that is known to have used a diatonic scale is of an earlier date than the flute found at the Neanderthal campsite.

C. The flute was made from a cave-bear bone, and the campsite at which the flute fragment was excavated was in a cave that also contained skeletal remains of cave bears.

D. Flutes are the simplest wind instrument that can be constructed to allow playing a diatonic scale.

E. The cave-bear leg bone used to make the Neanderthal flute would have been long enough to make a flute capable of playing a complete diatonic scale.

Argument Evaluation

Situation The arrangement of the holes in a bone fragment from a Neanderthal campsite matches part of the scale used in Western music since the Renaissance. Musicologists hypothesize from this that the scale

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scale used in Western music since the Renaissance. Musicologists hypothesize from this that the scale was developed thousands of years before Western musicians adopted it.

Reasoning *Which of the options, if true, would provide the most support for the musicologists' hypothesis?* One way to approach this question is to ask yourself, "If this option were false, would the hypothesis be *less* likely to be true?" If the Neanderthal bone fragment could *not* have been part of a flute that encompassed *the entire* seven-note diatonic scale, then the bone fragment's existence would not provide strong support for the hypothesis.

A. To the extent that this is even relevant, it tends to weaken the hypothesis; it makes less likely the possibility that Neanderthals used other types of musical instruments employing the diatonic scale.

B. This also weakens the hypothesis because it states that there is no known evidence of a certain type that would support the hypothesis.

C. The fact that the cave-bear bone fragment that was apparently a flute came from a site where many other cave-bear skeletal remains were found has little bearing on the hypothesis and in no way supports it.

D. This does not strengthen the hypothesis, for even if the option were false—even if a simpler instrument could be constructed that employed the diatonic scale—the existence of a flute employing the diatonic scale would provide no less support for the hypothesis.

E. **Correct.** This option most strongly supports the hypothesis.

The correct answer is E.

•

Which of the following most logically completes the passage?

The figures in portraits by the Spanish painter El Greco (1541–1614) are systematically elongated. In El Greco's time, the intentional distortion of human figures was unprecedented in European painting. Consequently, some critics have suggested that El Greco had an astigmatism, a type of visual impairment, that resulted in people appearing to him in the distorted way that is characteristic of his paintings. However, this suggestion cannot be the explanation, because _____.

A. several twentieth-century artists have consciously adopted from El Greco's paintings the systematic elongation of the human form

B. some people do have elongated bodies somewhat like those depicted in El Greco's portraits

C. if El Greco had an astigmatism, then, relative to how people looked to him, the elongated figures in his paintings would have appeared to him to be distorted

D. even if El Greco had an astigmatism, there would have been no correction for it available in the period in which he lived

E. there were non-European artists, even in El Greco's time, who included in their works human figures that were intentionally distorted

Argument Evaluation

Situation Figures in portraits by the Spanish painter El Greco are elongated. Some critics infer that this was because El Greco suffered from an astigmatism that made people appear elongated to him. But this explanation cannot be correct.

Reasoning *Which option would most logically complete the argument?* We need something that provides the best reason for thinking that the explanation suggested by critics—astigmatism—cannot be right. The critics' explanation might seem to work because ordinarily an artist would try to paint an image of a person so that the image would have the same proportions as the perceived person. So, if people seemed to El Greco to have longer arms and legs than they actually had, the arms and legs of the painted figures should appear to others to be longer than people's arms and legs normally are. This is how the explanation seems to make sense. But if astigmatism were the explanation, then the elongated images in his pictures should have appeared to El Greco to be too long: he would have perceived the images as longer than they actually are—and therefore as inaccurate representations of what he perceived. So, astigmatism cannot be a sufficient explanation for the elongated figures in his

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paintings.

A. Even if subsequent artists intentionally depicted human forms as more elongated than human figures actually are, and they did so to mimic El Greco's painted figures, that does not mean that El Greco's figures were intentionally elongated.

B. Although this option provides another possible explanation for El Greco's elongated figures, it provides no evidence that the people El Greco painted had such elongated figures.

C. **Correct**. El Greco would have perceived the images of people in his paintings as too long, relative to his perception of the people themselves. This means that even if El Greco did have astigmatism, that factor would not provide an answer to the question, "Why did El Greco paint images that he knew were distorted?"

D. The absence of an ability to correct astigmatism in El Greco's day does not undermine the hypothesis that it was astigmatism that caused El Greco to paint elongated figures.

E. Again, this suggests another possible explanation for the distortion—namely, that El Greco did it deliberately—but it does not provide any reason to think that this is the correct explanation (and that the critics' explanation is actually incorrect).

The correct answer is C.

•

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